

The Hidden Truth explained why your character's first answer is never the real one, and why the real one won't feel like a belief at all — it will feel like a fact they've never had reason to question. That leaves one problem unsolved: knowing what you're looking for is not the same as having a way to find it.

This document is that way. It's the actual instrument — a real technique borrowed from clinical practice, adapted for character work — along with the two checks that tell you whether you've reached the hidden truth or just a more convincing-sounding version of the justification. Read this before you open your coaching session. The coach will walk you through all three parts; this is what each one is doing, and why.

THE REAL TECHNIQUE

The single question at the center of this lesson — *what would this person have to believe for this behavior to feel like the only reasonable response?* — isn't a STRATUM invention. It's a plain-language version of the Downward Arrow Technique, developed by the psychiatrist David Burns and introduced in his 1980 book *Feeling Good*. Burns built it directly on Beck's schema theory, as a practical way to actually get a person from an automatic thought down to the core belief underneath it.

THE DOWNWARD ARROW TECHNIQUE

Burns, 1980

A questioning method that traces a chain of inference from a surface thought down to the core belief driving it, by repeatedly asking what the previous answer would mean if it were true — not asking once, but following the answer to its own answer, again and again, until the chain stops producing anything new.

That word repeatedly is the part most often missed. In clinical use, the therapist doesn't ask the question once and accept whatever comes back. They ask it, get an answer, then ask it again *of that answer* — treating each response as just another surface layer to press on, until the answers stop changing shape and start repeating the same underlying fear in different words. That's the signal the chain has hit bedrock.

THE CHAIN, IN MINIATURE

A real downward arrow, outside of fiction entirely: “My friend was rude to me.” What would that mean? “It means she doesn't care about me.” What would that mean? “It means I don't have people who really respect me.” What would that mean? “It means I'm not worth caring about.” Three questions. Three answers. Only the last one is a core belief — and notice it took repetition to get there, not a single well-phrased question.

WHY ONE ANSWER IS NEVER ENOUGH

This is the piece worth being explicit about before you start: your coaching session is going to ask you the Therapist's Question, and then it is going to ask it again on whatever you just said — and probably again after that. That isn't the coach being difficult. It's the technique working correctly. A single pass down the chain almost never reaches bedrock; it reaches the next layer of justification, which is exactly what a chain is made of until you run out of layers.

THE QUESTION — APPLIED RECURSIVELY

“What would this person have to believe — about themselves, about other people, or about how the world works — for this behavior to feel like the only reasonable response?”

Ask it about the behavior. Get an answer. Then ask it again — not about the behavior this time, but about the answer you just gave. Keep going. You'll know you've stopped too early if the next round of the question still has somewhere obvious to go. You'll know you've arrived when asking it again just produces a restatement of the same belief.

Watch this play out across a full chain with a character you already know from the Hidden Truth: Katniss Everdeen, and her anchor behavior of repeatedly stepping between danger and the people she loves.

ROUND 1 *“She loves the people she protects.”* Plausible, sincere, and exactly where a single pass of the question stops if you let it. This is the conscious justification — the mask, not the face underneath it.

ROUND 2 Ask it again, of that answer: what would it have to mean, for loving someone to require throwing herself into danger for them? *“I’m the only one who can keep them safe.”* Closer — but there's still an obvious next question sitting right there: why does it have to be her?

ROUND 3 Ask it once more: what would that mean, if she really is the only one? *“If I don't protect them, no one will — and they will be destroyed.”* Ask it again from here and nothing new arrives — every further question just restates this belief in different words. That repetition without new content is the actual finish line, not a hunch that it “sounds deep enough.”

Once you've stopped descending, you verify with the Causal Lock: "Because I believe ___, I must ___." Complete it with your candidate belief and the anchor behavior, and read it back. If the behavior follows from the belief without any gap — if you can't picture the character doing anything else, given what they believe — the lock holds.

Here's the part worth slowing down for: the lock tests whether the sentence is coherent, not whether the belief is real. A justification can complete that sentence just as cleanly as a genuine hidden truth can. Coherence alone won't tell the two apart.

PASSES THE LOCK — STILL SHALLOW

"Because I believe protecting people matters, I must protect them." Grammatically airtight. The behavior does follow from the belief. And it's still the conscious justification wearing a causal-lock sentence — a virtue, not a fear. Nothing here carries the vulnerability a real core belief should. Recall from the Hidden Truth: a belief with no fear, scarcity, or loss underneath it hasn't been excavated yet.

PASSES THE LOCK — AND REAL

"Because I believe no one will protect the people I love if I don't, I must position myself between them and whatever threatens them — every time, regardless of the cost to me." Also airtight. The difference isn't the grammar. It's that this belief has an edge to it — a specific fear about what happens if she's wrong — that the shallow version never had.

A clean lock is necessary. It is not sufficient on its own. Use it to confirm your belief is logically load-bearing — then use the next check to confirm it's the right belief.

THE INSTANCE TEST — PROVING THE BELIEF, NOT JUST THE SENTENCE

Your Surface Pattern work from Lesson 1 gave you three separate, real instances of the anchor behavior — not one anecdote, but a documented pattern across different people and different stakes. A hidden truth that only explains the instance you happened to be thinking about when you built the lock hasn't actually been tested yet.

Take the belief and run it against all three instances, one at a time: *does this belief explain why the behavior was the only possible response here — with this person, under this specific pressure — without needing extra reasoning bolted on?* If it explains two instances cleanly and strains on the third, the belief isn't wrong, but it isn't finished. A real hidden truth doesn't need help covering the data you already collected.

PREPARING FOR YOUR COACHING SESSION

Your coach is going to run you through exactly this sequence, in this order, and it's going to feel slower than you expect — that's the technique, not a delay. Here's the shape of what's coming:

- 1 The question, asked more than once. Your first answer will be treated as a starting point, not a destination. Expect to be asked what your own answer would mean, two or three times, before the coach treats anything as a candidate belief.
- 2 The Causal Lock. Once a candidate belief stops changing shape, you'll complete the "Because I believe ___, I must ___" sentence together and check that the behavior follows without a gap.
- 3 The Instance Test. The belief gets checked against all three instances from your Surface Pattern PDF — which is why that document needs to be attached before the session starts.
- 4 Final wording. Once the belief holds across all three checks, the coach will help you write the finished hidden truth and the finished causal lock — your two deliverables for this lesson.

One question, asked as many times as it takes.

That's the whole instrument.

DON'T STOP AT THE FIRST ROUND. KEEP ASKING.

NEXT

Knowing the technique is one thing. Knowing what it looks like when a session goes sideways — a belief that sounds deep but is still a virtue, a lock that holds on paper but not against the evidence — is another. The next resource is a field guide to exactly those failure points.

FURTHER READING

Burns, D. D. (1980). *Feeling Good: The New Mood Therapy*. William Morrow.

Beck, J. S. (2020). *Cognitive Behavior Therapy: Basics and Beyond* (3rd ed.). Guilford Press.

Beck, A. T. (1967). *Depression: Clinical, Experimental, and Theoretical Aspects*. Hoeber.